



English H+ Review Guide

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Range: City of Glass & Vocabulary Words 3&4

Note: Review Practices are UNOFFICIAL sources of reference and do NOT include or hint at questions in the actual exam!

Lexis Terms:

- Border – The line or frame around a comic panel.
- Gutter – The space between comic panels where the reader infers movement or time passing.
- Speech Bubble – A rounded shape that contains a character's spoken words.
- Emanata – Visual symbols (e.g., sweat drops, motion lines) showing emotion or movement.
- Tier – A horizontal row of comic panels.
- Icon – A simplified image that represents a character, object, or idea.
- Sound Effect – Onomatopoeic words (e.g., *BOOM*, *splash*) that convey sound within the scene.
- Caption – Text (often in a box) that provides narration or context outside of dialogue.
- Postmodernism: A literary movement marked by skepticism, irony, and rejection of universal truths or grand narratives.
- Fragmentation: A narrative technique breaking structure, time, or character continuity into disjointed parts.
- Meaning: Often questioned or destabilized in postmodern texts, suggesting multiple or no fixed interpretations.
- Irony: The use of language or structure to express something opposite or contradictory to the expected meaning.
- Intertextuality: Referencing or integrating other texts within a text to create new layers of meaning.
- Genre: A category or type of literature; postmodernism often blends or disrupts genres.
- Subversion: Undermining traditional norms, values, or expectations, often with a critical or satirical edge.
- Text/Paratext: The main body of a work (text) and supplementary materials like titles, forewords, or footnotes (paratext) that shape interpretation.

Core Information:

- *Original Author*: Paul Auster (from The New York Trilogy)
- *Adaptors*: Paul Karasik (Writer/Adapter), David Mazzucchelli (Artist)
- *Genre*: Postmodern Mystery / Existential Graphic Novel / Literary Adaptation
- *Key Themes*: Identity, Language, Reality vs. Illusion, Authorship, Obsession, Urban Alienation, Failure.

Plot & Premise:

- Daniel Quinn, a lonely mystery writer grieving his wife and son, receives a wrong-number call meant for "Paul Auster, Private Investigator."
- Intrigued/desperate, Quinn becomes "Paul Auster" and takes the case from the disturbed Peter Stillman Jr.
- The case: Protect Peter Stillman Jr. from his recently released father, Peter Stillman Sr., who subjected Peter Jr. to horrific language-deprivation experiments.
- Quinn begins obsessively trailing the enigmatic and seemingly harmless Stillman Sr. through NYC.

- The investigation spirals into a labyrinth of identities, coincidences, and philosophical questions.
- Quinn encounters the real Paul Auster (a writer), further blurring lines.
- Quinn's sense of self and reality disintegrates as the "case" becomes increasingly abstract and unsolvable.
- An ambiguous, unresolved ending leaves Quinn lost and broken.

Key Characters:

- Daniel Quinn: Protagonist. Writer of detective novels under the pseudonym "William Wilson." Emotionally isolated, becomes consumed by the case and his adopted identity.
- Peter Stillman Jr.: The "client." Traumatized, speaks in a unique, broken language due to his father's abuse. Represents the failure of language and connection.
- Peter Stillman Sr.: The "villain"? A former linguist/theologian who conducted cruel experiments on his son. Obsessed with the Tower of Babel and the Fall of Language. Appears frail and harmless, but his past is monstrous.
- Paul Auster (Real): A writer Quinn contacts. Represents the "real" author, indifferent to Quinn's plight. Highlights the theme of authorship and identity.
- Virginia Stillman: Peter Jr.'s wife. Primarily a conduit for the initial contact and payment. Represents the "normal" world Quinn leaves behind.

Major Themes:

- Identity & Doubles: Quinn becomes "Auster," writes as "Wilson." Stillman Sr. & Jr. are dark reflections. The real Auster appears. Constant questioning: "Who is who?"
- Language & Meaning: Stillman Sr.'s linguistic theories. Peter Jr.'s broken speech. Quinn's notebooks devolve into gibberish. The instability and inadequacy of words.
- Reality vs. Illusion/Construction: Is the case real? Is Quinn's perception reliable? NYC becomes a maze of signs and symbols. The graphic novel form emphasizes constructed realities.
- Obsession & Descent: Quinn's surveillance becomes all-consuming, leading to his physical and mental unraveling. The case replaces his life.
- The Failure of Detection: Subverts the detective genre. The mystery isn't solved; it dissolves. The detective fails utterly and is destroyed by the process.
- Authorship & Creation: Quinn writes fiction, adopts identities. Auster exists as both character and author. Meta-commentary on storytelling and creation.
- Isolation & Alienation: Quinn is profoundly alone. His connections (phone calls, surveillance) are impersonal and ultimately meaningless.

Motifs:

- The City (NYC) as Labyrinth: NYC is a character – vast, anonymous, full of signs and hidden meanings, isolating and disorienting.
- Notebook: archive filled with obsessive and fragmented writings; his too for case notes but then devolves as Quinn loses his grip on reality -> entries shift from surveillance to self-referential doubts mirroring his disintegration, also serves as a form of expression

- Telephone: story begins with the phone call, the start of Quinn attempting to create meaning in his own life; second phone call was from Auster where he reveals Stillman Sr.'s suicide, destroys Quinn's newfound purpose. Marks the end and the start as a callback
- Hand/Pen: The pen, first sold to Quinn by a deaf man with the note "Learn to Speak to Your Friends," becomes a symbol of self-expression. As Quinn opens up, his writing grows more subjective—seen in his reflections on homelessness (pp. 102–104), where the handwriting shifts into his own and the narration becomes philosophical. On pp. 88–89, the pen's direction mirrors his emotional state—poised to record Auster's insight, then stunned and inactive when expectations collapse. By pp. 130–131, Quinn is visually submerged, beginning with his pen, symbolizing how his identity dissolves with his loss of writing. His ability to express is his sense of self—once writing fails, so does he.
- Fingerprint: used to identify people, used in the form of a maze in the novel; symbolizes how Quinn feels lost no matter where he is – his confusion with his identity and existential meaning
- Eggs: appears initially along with humpty dumpty analogy; Stillman believes people must be "broken" before achieving greater meaning – may also correlate to Quinn's mental fragility especially after Auster's phone call notifying him about Stillman's death
- Max Work: protagonist of William Wilson's novel; the detective identity that Quinn envisioned himself being – Quinn has shaped himself through the lens of Max Work